

A framework for stronger relationships

PRACTICAL WAYS TO NAVIGATE CHALLENGES AND BUILD DEEPER CONNECTIONS.



Conflicts can be positive

Conflict is usually associated with a negative event that makes us feel threatened and moves us into a state of protection. However, when handled with an open mind instead of judgment, defensiveness, or blame, conflict can cause learning.



Gain new perspectives

Different views can help us see the bigger picture.



Adapt and grow together

Conflict helps people adapt, grow, and solve challenges.



Turn feedback into progress

Instead of rewards or criticism, we can provide constructive feedback and new ideas for the future.



Be ready for difficult conversations

Key to being successful in having a difficult conversation is the awareness that we need to shift from a state of protection to one of adaptation. Being open to learning and doing things differently is harder than we might expect and requires deliberate efforts.



Let go of old patterns

Avoid blaming or assuming the other person is not making an effort.



Stay open and curious

Be willing to understand the situation from the other person's perspective.



Work toward a shared conclusion

Recognize that our past patterns may no longer serve us, and help both sides reach a meaningful outcome.





Attention

Attention means turning toward the other person — listening deeply without judgment, distraction, or the desire to respond.



What are some things people have done to make you feel that they were giving you 100% of their attention?

How did it feel? How might you demonstrate that kind of attention in your next conversation?



It's no surprise: we like people who receive us without judgment.

What is more surprising is just how much this matters, and how little we do it. When people pay attention to us, we feel a sense of acceptance and a desire for connection. When people turn away from us or ignore us, we feel rejected.

In fact, according to the Gottman Institute, this turning away and ignoring of “bids for connection” is the number one predictor of divorce. While our work environments are a bit different, the same idea holds true: the small ways in which we either pay attention and turn towards someone, or turn away from them, affect the quality of our connections.



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“The biggest communication problem is we do not listen to understand. We listen to reply.”

— Stephen Covey

Why Attention Matters



Creates a sense of acceptance



Builds deeper connection



Prevents feelings of rejection



Strengthens the quality of relationships

Tips for your next conversation

With preparation, awareness, and focus, you can give your full attention and create more meaningful conversations.



Before the Conversation

Prepare yourself so you can be fully present.

01



Practice pausing and adopt an open and curious mindset, so you can be fully present in the conversation.

02



Envision the conversation going well and focus on the positive outcome you want to achieve.

03



Prioritize what truly needs your attention now. Ask yourself, "Do I have the time and energy right now to give this conversation the attention it deserves?"

04



Minimize distractions, such as finding a quiet place or turning off your email notifications.



During the Conversation

Give your full attention and build deeper understanding.

01



Show attention non-verbally, such as turning toward the person, making eye contact, nodding, or giving other non-verbal cues.

02



Challenge yourself to truly listen without feeling the urge to respond.

03



Summarize what the other person said, using their own words, to ensure you understand them.

04



Try not to evaluate or judge, even if their reaction is different from what you expected. You don't need to withhold your reaction forever, but in the moment, focus on understanding.



Optional: Practice Attention

Try a simple exercise to strengthen your ability to give attention.



The easy part: ask someone, "How are you?"



The harder part: listen fully, silently, and without immediately jumping in with questions, for two minutes. (If the person responds with the usual "I'm well," repeat your question or perhaps ask, "How are you, really?")



Reflect on how that felt as a listener.



Find a colleague to practice with. Take turns and debrief the experience as both the responder and the listener.

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Vulnerability

Letting your guard down allows you to show your authentic self, build deeper connections, and create a more open and trusting environment.



When was the last time someone truly let their guard down with you or shared something that was surprising? What did it have on you?

When was the last time you let your guard down?
Do you feel you are regularly showing your most authentic self?



Vulnerability is one of the first qualities we look for in others.

It signals that they are approachable, human, and someone we can connect with.



Research shows vulnerability is particularly important for leaders, those with more power in a relationship, or role models.

It makes it okay for others to do the same, and builds an environment of creativity, inclusion, and psychological safety.



“Vulnerability is the core of shame and fear and our struggle for worthiness, but it appears that it’s also the birthplace of joy, of creativity, of belonging, of love. Vulnerability is not weakness; it’s our greatest measure of courage.”

— Brené Brown



Why Vulnerability Matters



Builds deeper connections



Unlocks creativity and new ideas



Creates a more inclusive and psychologically safe environment

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Tips for your next conversation

Practicing vulnerability can help you build deeper connections, foster trust, and create more meaningful conversations.



1. Explore Your Vulnerabilities

Here are four common feelings of vulnerability that we experience as humans. Which do you experience most often?



Not Enough

The feeling of not being or doing enough, being wrong, not having the answers, being an imposter, and being found out.



Not Belonging

The feeling of not being a (loved) part of the team, letting others down, being misunderstood.



Not in Control

The feeling of not being able to fix, not being able to help, losing power over a situation.



Not Matter

The feeling of not being focused on the right purpose, of focusing on things that don't matter, of insignificance.



2. Reflect More Deeply

Take a few moments to think about the following questions:

01

Where do you come from? What impact has a figure such as a parent or colleague had on you?

02

What are the formative experiences (from any point in your life) that shaped who you are as a person?

03

Which of your traits are often seen as strengths, but can also be weaknesses?



3. Address Your Vulnerabilities

Acknowledging the ways in which we feel vulnerable is an important first step. Sharing them can build stronger relationships.



Imagine the next time that vulnerability is likely to come up for you.



Write down — what it might sound like if you were to share this vulnerability with others.



Consider what the outcome might be.



In Preparation

Set yourself up for a more meaningful conversation.

01



Tune in to what you are feeling, without judgment, to maximize your own awareness.

02



Reflect on what things you are worried about revealing and what brings you discomfort. Sit with these, get curious, and take a step further to reflect on the guards you put up.

03



Consider something important to you that you have wanted to share, but haven't. Ask yourself why you haven't yet, and what it would take to do so.

04



Give yourself permission not to share if you do not feel comfortable or safe doing so. Listen to your gut — sometimes it is ok to not be vulnerable.



During the Conversation

Be open, honest, and intentional.

01



Share your experience using "I" statements, acknowledging your own emotions, fears, and challenges.

02



State your hopes or intentions, overall and for the relationship.

03



Acknowledge your role in the situation (e.g., "I believe I created anxiety by not communicating that decision ..."), including any assumptions or misinterpretations you might have had.

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Empathy

Empathy is the ability to truly understand and feel what others are experiencing. It helps us build stronger relationships, lead more effectively, and create a more inclusive environment.



We think we listen, but very rarely do we listen with real understanding, true empathy. Yet listening, of this very special kind, is one of the most potent forces for change that I know.

— Carl Rogers



Take a moment to reflect

When was the last time you felt deeply listened to? What about the last time you felt someone tried to put themselves in your shoes? Is there anyone in your life you could do the same for?



Empathy drives better leadership

Empathy and leadership performance are highly linked. Multiple studies show that empathy is one of the top competencies for good leadership, is linked to superior performance, and is one of the strongest indicators of senior executive effectiveness.



40%

of business leaders have proficient empathy skills.



Higher Performance

Empathy is linked to superior performance.



Stronger Connections

Empathy deepens our relationships with others.

Why Empathy Matters



Helps us understand different perspectives



Builds trust and stronger relationships



Leads to better decisions and higher performance

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Tips for your next conversation

Practicing empathy can help you listen deeper, understand different perspectives, build stronger relationships, and create a more inclusive and meaningful environment.



Levels of Listening

Empathy requires the ability to listen deeply and understand another person's perspective. Reflect on these levels and notice where you usually are — and where you can grow.

0



Level 0

No attention, just preparing a response.

1



Level 1

Downloading information, quick to judge.

2



Level 2

Gathering factual data without judgment (keeping an open mind).

3



Level 3

Understanding the other person's experiences and emotions (having an open heart); supporting their growth, beginner's mindset, and other resilient mindsets (e.g., ask yourself "what can I learn about this person's experience?").



"Empathy is not just about understanding what others say, but also about feeling what they feel."

— Carl Rogers



In Preparation

Prepare yourself to listen more fully.

01



Set an intention to listen fully (e.g., "what can I learn?" instead of "how can I explain or convince?").

02



Keep an open mind, and surface and challenge your assumptions.

03



Take a positive stance towards the other person and assume good intentions.



During the Conversation

Listen with full attention and show empathy in action.

01



Listen deeply without interrupting; withhold judgment and stay curious.

02



Be open to feeling (not just understanding) some of the other person's emotions.

03



Inquire and reflect back what you are hearing to demonstrate your understanding of their experience, emotions, fears, and needs (e.g., "What I'm sensing as I listen to you is ...").

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Compassion

Compassion is the ability to notice others' struggles, care about their well-being, and take meaningful action to help.



Reflection Questions

Take a moment to reflect on your own experience.

01



What acts of compassion have you seen at your organization?

02



How might you demonstrate compassion today or tomorrow?



Why Compassion Matters

Research shows that compassion has a powerful and tangible impact.



Better Well-being

Improves mental and physical health for both the giver and receiver.



Greater Motivation

Increases energy, engagement, and sense of purpose.



Stronger Relationships

Builds trust, collaboration, and a more inclusive environment.



Ways to Practice Compassion

Start small. Consistent actions can create a big difference.

01



Be Present

Notice and pay attention to what others are experiencing.

02



Show You Care

Acknowledge their feelings, even if you cannot fully solve their problem.

03



Take Meaningful Action

Offer support, lend a hand, or connect them with the right resources.

04



Make It a Habit

Look for everyday opportunities to show kindness and understanding.

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“Compassion is so often the solution.”

— Anonymous



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Tips for your next conversation

Meditation for compassion can help you be more present, calm, and open-hearted—so you can show greater care and kindness in your daily interactions.

Before You Begin



In preparation

Put yourself in their shoes and cultivate an intention to help and support the other person, even if you don't fully agree with them.



During

Communicate an honest desire to be of service, ask how they would best feel supported, and offer specific help or a small gesture of kindness.

Guided Meditation for Compassion

Follow these steps to cultivate a deeper sense of compassion for yourself and others.

1



Find a comfortable position

Sit with your back supported, lie down, or whatever feels best. Take a few deep breaths to center yourself in this present moment.

2



Bring your attention to your heart

Focus on how the breath feels in your heart area.

3



Start with self-compassion

Take a moment to care for yourself and acknowledge that you want strength, health, safety, and happiness. Continue to breathe in and out and repeat these phrases out loud:

- May I be happy.
- May I be healthy and at ease.
- May I be free from pain and suffering.

4



Extend compassion to someone you care about

Bring to mind someone who shows you unconditional love and kindness. Continue to breathe in and out, and repeat these phrases:

- May you be happy.
- May you be healthy and at ease.
- May you be free from pain and suffering.

5



Extend compassion to someone challenging

Bring to mind someone you are currently having difficulties with. As you repeat these phrases, continue to generate that feeling of real compassion.

- May you be happy.
- May you be healthy and at ease.
- May you be free from pain and suffering.

6



Radiate compassion to all

Finally, extend loving kindness to all beings.

- May all beings be happy, healthy, and free from pain and suffering.

7



Return to the present

Bring your attention back to your heart area. Take a few more deep breaths and open your eyes.

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PRACTICE IN ACTION

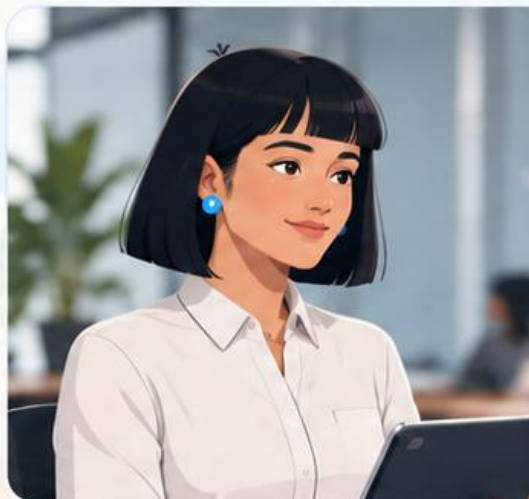
Knowledge check: Applying AVEC

The following scenario is an opportunity for you to practice applying AVEC. As you advise Alisha and Marino, consider how you could apply these techniques in your own life.



Applying AVEC

The following scenario is an opportunity for you to practice applying AVEC. As you advise Alisha and Marino, consider how you could apply these techniques in your own life.



01

Meet Alisha

Alisha is a product owner who is responsible for the project's outcome. She is also responsible for driving the delivery of a new software product for her business unit.



Reflection points

- How could you advise Alisha using AVEC?
- Which AVEC techniques are most relevant in this situation?



02

Meet Marino

Marino is Alisha's colleague and a software engineer responsible for developing, designing, and testing the software product.



Reflection points

- How could you advise Marino using AVEC?
- Which AVEC techniques are most relevant in this situation?

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PRACTICE IN ACTION

Knowledge check: Applying AVEC

Read the scenario below and choose the best response.
This is an opportunity to practice how you can apply AVEC in a real-life situation.



Scenario

You probably need to have a tough conversation with Marino. It sounds like he has been missing deadlines for a while. There's no sense dragging this out further.

Select the best answer and click **Submit**.

- ☐ Why hasn't the team leader been holding Marino accountable? You need to tell her that she can't let Marino get away with this poor performance.
- ☐ I'd be frustrated too. It's not fair to the team. You should have an honest conversation with Marino and share the effect that this is having on all of you. Make sure he really understands the negative impact he is having.
- ☒ It's obvious this is really stressful—it's a tough situation. Could you share how you're feeling with Marino and the impact it has on the team, and then ask him what's going on with him and how he's feeling? Maybe there's more to the situation than you can see.
- ☐ Let's bring the issue to our project manager so she can figure out a path forward. We just need to get things back on track, both for the team and for your review.

Submit →

How can I best respond using AVEC?

I'm feeling overwhelmed...



Correct
That's right!



You helped Alisha to reframe the situation. In a potentially difficult conversation, being able to reframe is an important first step. It makes it more likely each person will walk away understanding the other better, and that together they will have improved both the situation and their working relationship.

This response demonstrates AVEC:



Attention

You thanked him for being open.



Vulnerability

You shared a personal example of a challenging situation.



Empathy

You acknowledged that it is challenging.



Compassion

You offered to help him find a way forward.



Key takeaway

Using AVEC helps you approach difficult conversations with greater understanding, connection, and a focus on finding solutions together.

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WRAP UP

Key takeaways

In this module, you have learned how to use the AVEC framework to build stronger, more meaningful relationships—at work and in life.



Core takeaway

Use the AVEC framework to build and improve your relationships by practicing:



Attention

Be fully present with others.



Vulnerability

Be open and authentic.



Empathy

Seek to understand others' perspectives.



Compassion

Take action to support others.



Recommended resources

Continue your learning journey with these curated resources.



VIDEO

The power of vulnerability

Learn how vulnerability can strengthen trust, connection, and collaboration.



ARTICLE

Tuning in, turning outward:

Cultivating compassionate leadership in a crisis



ARTICLE

Want to improve your relationship?

Start paying more attention to bids.



Keep practicing

The more you apply AVEC in your daily interactions, the more natural and impactful it will become.